

AuthorsLab × High Line Publishing

Publishing infrastructure, proposed as a partnership

WORKING DRAFT V0.8 — INTERNAL — NOT FOR SEND — repositioned 30 September: this document describes the publisher product only. One section awaits its owner. Final version follows re-mark, adversarial read and verification.

High Line is building a new publishing operation — and the systems around its list, at the same time as the list itself. AuthorsLab proposes itself as **publishing infrastructure**: a connected environment your editors, designers and marketers work *with*, adopted progressively, that develops alongside the operation rather than requiring High Line to build every component internally.

One commitment shapes every page that follows: **the system exists to multiply what your professionals produce, never to replace them**. It prepares, checks, records, surfaces, and hands off. It does not write, edit, design, publish, or decide. Where those verbs appear in this document, the subject is one of your people.

1 — What we are not claiming

You read proposals for what is missing, so the missing comes first. **No note, no cover, no copy reaches an author or a channel without a named person at High Line releasing it**. The system produces preparation for your professionals' judgement; the judgement, and the byline, are theirs.

Where our line ends. The system runs to a finished, edited manuscript, its editorial record, and cover artwork ready for typography. The manuscript compiler exists and assembles a complete book — front matter, chapters, back matter — as a single styled document; converting that into distributor-accepted files is not yet working, and what “accepted” requires depends on who receives them. So the question we will ask rather than answer: **what does your handoff to Hachette actually require, and in what form — and who does that work for you today?**

Dates, and exactly what they measure. Each title can carry a target date — set by you, revisable, with who set it and when recorded — and the list measures against it: overdue outranks at-risk outranks stalled outranks moving. Where no date is set the surface says so; an undated book is never called “*on track*”, because on-track is a claim against a date and we only make it against one you set. The system does not forecast — it will not say “*this book will miss March*” until a throughput record exists to say so honestly, and the pilot is where that record begins.

A method, not just a promise. Where a control's machinery does not exist, the control does not appear — every control passes through one gate that hides what has no substrate; we removed working-looking controls from these screens for exactly that reason. The same rule produced this document: nothing here is in the present tense unless it is running in production, and §4 says precisely which parts those are.

And no integration is claimed. Nothing here connects to your existing systems, Hachette's machinery, contracts or royalties. What we propose runs alongside what you have, with the record it produces as the argument for what comes next.

2 — What the system is — four modules and an instrument

2.1 — Editorial. Alex, Sam and Jordan — the system's three editorial engines — run a **preliminary pass** over a full manuscript or a single chapter, producing structured, chapter-referenced notes. A High Line editor reviews the notes, edits them, discards what is wrong, and releases a **notes package to the author under their own name**. It does not edit your books, and it sends nothing to a writer. Where the time goes back: **shorter queues, not cheaper editing** — the constraint in an editorial department is a senior editor's free week, not an hourly rate, and a manuscript that arrives already read starts that week part-finished. Copy editing enforces **your house style sheet** — checkable in the first chapter it touches, which is how you should test it.

2.2 — Design. Cover status across the list; **intake of finished artwork from your designers' own tools** — versioned, attributed, with a record of who approved what; concepts sent to an author for comment; and a page-layout preview with a **per-page snag list** — widows, orphans, single-word pages, bad breaks. It does not compete with Photoshop or InDesign, and is not trying to: **your designers keep their own tools; AuthorsLab gives their work somewhere to live, a version history, and a record of who approved it.** Where the time goes back: the checking and the chasing, not the craft.

2.3 — Production readiness. Under your architecture — High Line finances, the imprints process, Hachette delivers — our job is the **handoff**, not distribution. So this module is a readiness gate: metadata completeness, front and back matter, format checks, the snag list, assembled into one verdict — **a title is provably ready, or provably not, with the list of what is missing.** We do not publish; we make a title provably ready to be published. Where the time goes back: rejected submissions — every incomplete handoff is a cycle, and every cycle is weeks.

2.4 — Marketing. A **per-title asset pack drafted for your marketer to edit:** positioning, comparable titles, keyword metadata, jacket copy, retailer copy at three lengths, sales-sheet blurb. And because the system holds the handoff date, it knows when the campaign has to start. It does not run campaigns, buy media, or decide positioning. Where the time goes back: the repetitive half — eight pieces of copy at four lengths per title is production work; what the book *is* stays with your marketer.

The instrument under all four — the list view. One screen for the whole list, live: **sorted by what needs attention, filterable per imprint.** Each row says where the book is, who it is waiting on, and how long since anything has moved. When nothing is late it says so. A book whose stations are all complete shows the boundary as a state: *our stations are complete — the handoff sits with you.* The first book to sort to the top of our own test list was waiting on the publisher, not on us — a system whose first act is to show you your own bottleneck is making a different kind of claim than one that only reports ours. Every book moves through recorded stations — what was done, who ran it, what has to be true for it to leave, and who closes that gate — and every decision is an attributed, append-only entry. Every machine action is metered per call, per manuscript, per station, and a **preliminary pass that fails costs us and bills you nothing.**

3 — Adoption — phased, with the authority dial in your hands

Phase 1 — Editorial foundation (this proposal): the publisher workspace, your titles, the preliminary-pass workflow and the list view — ending, deliberately, at handoff to composition. Two pilot titles, one per imprint, free until the first preliminary pass completes (\$5).

Phase 2 — Composition & production: turning the finished manuscript into the files your channel accepts — composition, formatting, cover typography — specified against your answer to the Hachette question, with commercials agreed then, not now.

Phase 3 — further capability where there is a clear operational fit, decided together.

Within every phase, the authority dial: Observe → Assist → Operate, per module, switches held by your admin, not by us. At Observe the system **changes nothing about the work; it records what was done** — your people keep working exactly as they do. Cover design at Observe means your designer works and the system records; that is the dial doing precisely what this document promises. The switch mechanics are in build; until they ship, levels are set with us rather than self-served.

4 — What runs in production today, and what we build with you

Running today: the production line and its recorded stations, the book surface and drill-down, the manuscript reader, cover artwork intake and generation, the attributed decision record, the metering, and the list view — attention-sorted, imprint-filterable, verified on screen against live data. Target dates with provenance and the overdue/at-risk/stalled/moving measurement. Front and back matter, listing metadata, pricing and channel

selection captured as structured data.

In build, named honestly: the working surfaces for organisations, imprints, seats and permissions — foundations applied and their enforcement demonstrated in production, screens in progress. Per-module authority switches. The review-and-release workflow that puts a High Line editor's name on a notes package. Designer upload. The readiness verdict as a single gate. The marketing asset pack.

SECTION TO FOLLOW — staff & permissions: what a High Line admin can do on day one, in plain language. Owner: identity & billing.

5 — What it costs

Two numbers, GBP, nothing metered behind either.

Platform fee	£750 / month	The instrument: whole backlog, every seat, every imprint, at whatever authority levels you set.
Per title worked	£400, once	Fired when the system completes its first editorial station for that title. Opens the full editorial line to that book.
Pilot	Free	Two titles, one per imprint — converting only when the first editorial journey completes.

Per title entering the editorial workflow: £400, once — fired when the system completes its first preliminary pass for that title. It opens the full editorial module to that book — all three engines, at your authority level, re-runs within fair use. **How much of it you route through the system is your choice; the price does not change with it.** A book loaded but never worked is never billed; a book whose launch is delayed downstream is not billed again for waiting.

Principles: no per-seat pricing; no usage meters; no overage charges; a clear relationship between payment and actual title activity. You already account per title — £400 lands as one line inside a cost structure you already run, beside professional editorial at £1,600—£8,000 for a single pass on the same book. **It is not a replacement for that spend and is not offered as one — the editor still reads the book.** A fifteen-title year is **£15,000**; a thirty-title year **£21,000**; and if your people do everything and use only the visibility layer, a year is **£9,000 flat** — a floor we designed, not a loophole.

6 — The partnership, stated as the exchange it is

We are not proposing a bespoke build, and not proposing you adopt something finished — both would be untrue. The honest description is an exchange: **you get infrastructure shaped around how a publishing house actually runs, at a stage early enough that the shaping is real. We get something we cannot buy — sustained access to professionals who know what a publishing operation requires.** Carl, our co-founder, will be personally available to work with your team on implementation — setup, workflow fit, the first passes — and the feedback loop is the point, not a courtesy.

Four questions we would rather ask than answer — none blocks the pilot; the system runs without them and is better with them, and that difference is roughly the difference between a tool and infrastructure: **what does your handoff to Hachette actually require, and in what form** (your production people); **do your designers work in their own tools and hand us files, or would they work in ours** (your design lead); **what does a target date mean in your house — handoff, publication, or both** (you); **where does a notes package sit in your editorial process, and who signs it** (your editors).

7 — Proposed next step

One small decision: **agree the two pilot titles, one from Odessa, one from Antidote.**

Then, in order: we establish the High Line workspace — your organisation, your two imprints, your team's access arriving with it; the pilot titles enter the line; the first preliminary passes run and your editors handle the first notes packages; and we review together before agreeing the next phase.

The objective is not to sell High Line software. It is to help a new publisher establish modern publishing infrastructure with as little friction as possible — and to earn each next phase by what the last one measurably did.

Working positions: UK contracting entity · GBP · invoiced net-30 — confirmed at signature. Opening terms for High Line specifically, not a rate card. Internal draft: voice pass, register pass, re-mark against open screens, adversarial read and claim-by-claim verification precede any send; Paul and Carl own the send.